

"Excuse me, your highness," the boy said quietly. "But there are dragons under the hill."

"Who is this boy talking nonsense about dragons?" bellowed the king. "I have no time for such childish stories, I have a fortress to build!"

"My name is Merlin," the boy replied, "and you need to free the dragons before you build the castle. They have been trapped in a fierce battle for over a thousand moons." The king stared at the boy. "Well, boy," he said, putting his arm around Merlin's shoulder, "I am sure you are telling tales, but I have no other ideas. Lead the way!"

Merlin, though just a boy, had power and wisdom beyond his years. He led the crowd to a lake near the castle grounds and around the hillside, until they were stopped by a huge boulder. "Fetch the ropes," the king ordered.

They wrapped ropes around the boulder and dragged it away. Peering into the dark, the king spotted two sleeping dragons, one red, one white. His gasp woke the dragons, who—desperate to escape—darted out and shot into the sky.

A snarling bundle of red and white, all teeth and claws and scales, rolled around the sky like a storm. Terrible cries sent out shockwaves that stripped the trees of leaves and parted the clouds in the sky.

The red dragon of Wales and the white dragon of the Saxons screeched and snarled and scratched and scowled, as intense flames flashed from their nostrils.

Finally, after a week of battle, the red dragon sank its jaws into the white dragon's underbelly, and its white scales turned red with blood. It fell from the sky and sank to the bottom of the lake.

"We can build now," Merlin advised the king. "It is safe."

And so, by nightfall the people were finally able to feast within their fortress walls. While high above them, on the tallest of the towers, looking out across Wales, perched the red dragon.

